

May the Flow Be with You

Enabling Risk-Based Validation Cadence

SAFe & AI
SUMMIT
AMSTERDAM, NETHERLANDS

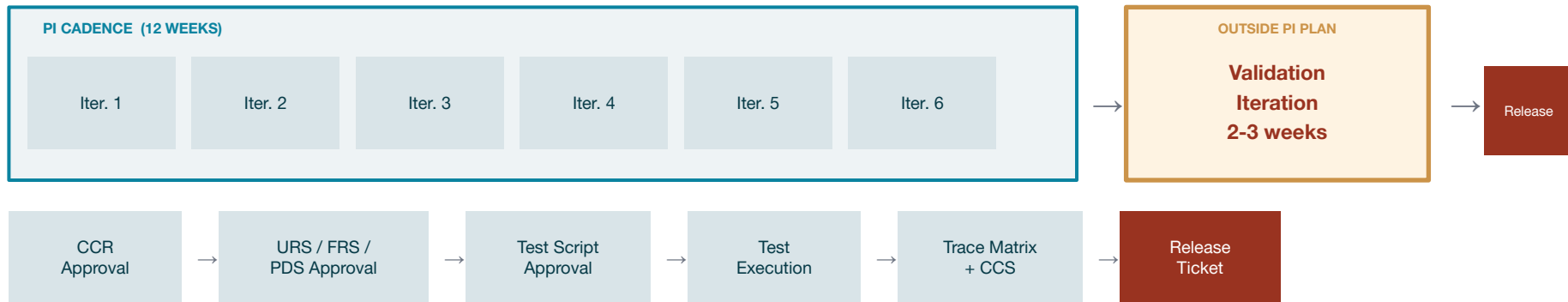




Marcin Cieśliński

Enterprise Agile Expert
Adesso SE

*"Code is done, business is waiting —
and now the CSV team needs 2–3 weeks
before we can go to production."*



9 approval gates per change · 2–3 weeks end-to-end · every story, regardless of risk

How many of you recognise this pattern in your ART?

False confidence and batched validation create late-stage surprises

SAFe REFERENCES

- Flow Accelerator #8: Remediate Legacy Policies
- Flow Accelerator #5: Work in Smaller Batches
- Flow Accelerator #2: Address Bottlenecks

FALSE POSITIVE FEASIBILITY

- Sprint demos showed happy paths — edge cases and negative tests were skipped
- Validation gaps surfaced only weeks later, during CSV execution phase
- Each gap meant re-opening approved documents and restarting the approval chain

2–3 weeks

average rework delay after gaps found in CSV phase

LOW FLOW EFFICIENCY

- Validation iteration outside the PI cadence — no fixed duration, not in any ART plan
- At PI Planning: teams committed to features, never to a release date
- One CSV team for the entire ART — same requirements tested 3 times over

3×

same requirements re-tested by dev, system test, and CSV team separately

HOW EVERY RELEASE WORKED



Only 20% of stories needed thorough validation — yet every story went through the full CSV process

SAFe REFERENCES

- Flow Accelerator #8: Remediate Legacy Policies
- SAFe Principle #1: Take an economic view

BEFORE: 100% of stories → identical full CSV process (all treated as HIGH RISK)

↓ risk classification created three tiers ↓

HIGH RISK

20%

of stories

Full test scripts
+ edge cases
+ separate approval

LOW RISK

50%

of stories

Reduced testing rigor:
1 test case per group
of requirements

NO VALIDATION

30%

of stories

Still tested
Enablers, spikes,
UX/UI work —
no CSV needed

30% of stories had been going through full CSV process for years — and needed none of it.

- Flow Accelerator #8: Remediate Legacy Policies
- SAFe Principle #1: Take an economic view

Risk-based scoping eliminated validation for ~60% of test cases without dropping compliance requirement

BEFORE

100% of stories — identical full CSV process (all HIGH RISK treatment)

AFTER

HIGH 20%

LOW 50%

NONE 30%

	BEFORE (all stories)	AFTER
High Risk (20%)	Full test scripts Edge + negative cases Separate approval per doc	Full test scripts Edge + negative cases Separate approval per doc
Low Risk (50%)	Full test scripts Edge + negative cases Separate approval per doc	One test case per group of requirements Reduced documentation
No validation (30%)	Full test scripts Edge + negative cases Separate approval per doc	Still tested , but no CSV process Enablers, spikes, UX/UI excluded entirely

Compliance is not diminished — it is intentionally focused on the areas where it's most critical.

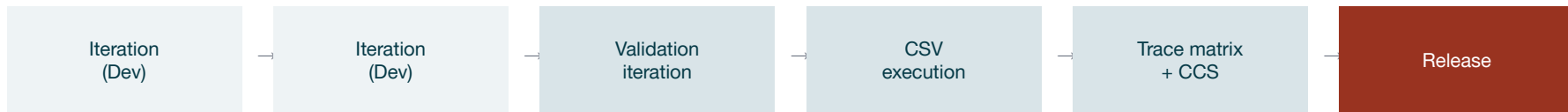
Embedding validation in Definition of Done eliminated the phase-gate bottleneck

SAFe REFERENCES

- Flow Accelerator #4: Get Faster Feedback
- Flow Accelerator #5: Work in Smaller Batches
- Built-in Quality

BEFORE — DoD: "Feature Complete"

100% of stories → same process · nobody could forecast the release date



AFTER — DoD: "Validated to Risk Level"

Risk AC in every story · ART commits release date at PI Planning



IT QC review triggered only on test failure — not on every execution

Integrating CSV specialists into teams removed handoffs and made compliance a shared responsibility

SAFe REFERENCES

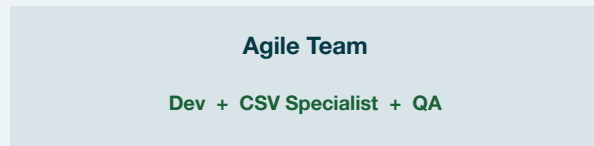
- Flow Accelerator #3: Minimize Handoffs
- CALMR
- Built-in Quality: Shift Left

BEFORE



- One CSV team serving multiple ARTs as a shared service
 - single point of failure for every release
- 9 approval gates per change
- CCR required per individual change
- "We are the benchmark for auditors"

AFTER



- CSV specialist embedded in the ART or teams — coaches, doesn't gate
- CCR raised once per Release, not per change
- Risk-proportional DoD: ART can commit release dates at PI Planning
- "We pass the audit. Nothing more, nothing less."

Risk-based validation cut lead time ~45% and lifted formal approval from 60% of test cases

SAFe REFERENCES

- Flow Accelerator #8: Remediate Legacy Policies
- Continuous Learning Culture / Measure & Grow
- Team Topologies: Enabling Team

Lead Time

2–3 weeks → **3–5 days** ↓ **~45%**

Request to validated production release

Test Cases

Full validation of cases for every story

Risk-scoped Test case validation only

↓ **60%**

TC validation eliminated for all 'no validation' stories + reduced for 1/3 of low-risk stories

Approval Gates

~9 per change CCR per change → **~5 per release CCR per Release** ↓ **fewer**

Single risk-based approval replaces separate URS / FRS sign-off chain

PI Planning — Release Predictability

Release date unknown

Committed at PI Planning

↑ **certain**

Validation AC in stories — ART can forecast release date from day 1 of PI

No audit findings attributed to the new approach · IT QC reviews now triggered only on test failure for validated products.

Process changes were straightforward — shifting a deeply rooted validation mindset was the real work

"The CSV team boasted about being the benchmark for auditors. The business just wanted to pass the audit — nothing more, nothing less."

1

FRAME

Leadership positioned it as improving compliance accuracy — not lowering standards

→

2

PILOT

Ran with one team · measured lead time before/after · validated the model · then scaled

→

3

CO-DESIGN

CSV specialists co-designed the process — shifting from gatekeepers to coaches

→

4

MAKE VISIBLE

Auto-generated trace matrix and test reports gave auditors more data, not less

The CSV team's fear was not about auditors. It was about relevance. Addressing that directly was the turning point.

Compliance and speed aren't opposites — with the right approach, you get both

1

Change management is not a soft skill — the CSV team's fear of irrelevance was the real blocker, not the auditors

2

Classify first, validate second — 30% of your stories may need no formal CSV approval. All are still tested. Find them.

3

Compliance and speed aren't opposites — pull validation into flow, scope it by risk, and make it a team responsibility

Go back and ask your teams:

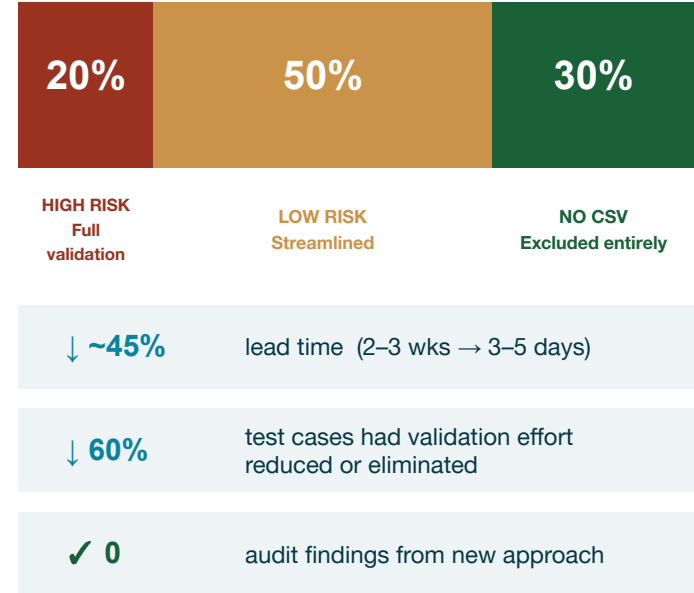
"What percentage of our validation effort is truly risk-justified?"

Marcin Cieśliński

Enterprise Agile Expert | Adesso SE

<https://www.linkedin.com/in/mcieslinski/>

One team's answer:



THANK YOU

Please rate this session!

